

Band Advance System — How It Works

Brian Lloyd — 3CDC Events & Production

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The problem

Booking a band used to mean someone remembering to email them, chasing down a stage plot, and copying whatever came back into the show paperwork by hand. Across a full season of acts, something always slipped — a stage plot that never arrived, a confirmation nobody sent, a band we never heard back from at all. We built this to close that gap, and so the paperwork used at load-in is the same information the band actually gave us, not something retyped from memory a week later.

The stack

It's a small, self-hosted system, not a vendor product. A Flask web app runs both the public advance form and the internal booking form, under gunicorn, on our own server — the same box that runs our other internal tools. It's set to restart itself automatically if it ever crashes. Behind it sits a dedicated Postgres database, kept separate from everything else on that server so nothing else can touch or break it. n8n, our workflow automation tool, owns the timed checks and the Gmail integration — it's the piece that actually creates a draft in our inbox and knows when to nudge us. Cloudflare's tunnel puts the public form on a real address, advance.tinydoorstudios.com, without opening a port on our network.

What's stored

The core of it is four tables. An artist is a band, one record forever — matched by name, with a normalized copy of that name (lowercase, extra spaces collapsed) sitting alongside it, so "The Whiskey Rebellion" and a slightly different spacing or capitalization on a second booking still land on the same artist instead of splitting into two. A show is one booking: a band, a venue, a date. A submission is one completed advance form, tied to both. Files are whatever they upload — stage plot, input list.

From booking to draft

Staff logs a new booking in a short internal form — band, venue, date, a few schedule details. The moment that's submitted, a pipeline runs in the background: it seeds the booking into our master spreadsheet, builds the show's folder and document package in the right venue tree, and renders the outreach email. That email isn't sent from here — it's handed to n8n, which creates it as a real Gmail draft sitting in our account, untouched, as soon as the booking exists. It used to wait until three weeks out to even draft itself; now it drafts the moment we know about the show, and just waits for its send date.

If the database happens to be down when someone submits, we don't lose anything — every submission gets written to disk first, and Postgres gets it best-effort after. The form can't break just because the database had a bad moment.

The three-week and one-week checks

Every morning, n8n checks the database for two things. First: any show that's crossed into the three-week-out window and hasn't been flagged yet gets flagged "ready to send," and a summary lands in my inbox saying the draft's ready. Second: any show inside a week of the date that we've heard nothing back on gets a follow-up drafted the same way — held, not sent. There's a guardrail for a show booked late enough to land inside both windows on day one: it gets the initial draft only, never a follow-up in that same run, since following up on something we haven't even sent yet doesn't make sense. Nothing in this loop sends an email by itself. Every draft still needs a person to open Gmail and hit send. That's not a gap — it's on purpose. We wanted the busywork automated, not the judgment calls.

What the band sees

The link in that email opens the band's own advance form — no login, no account, just a signed link tied to that one booking so it can't be guessed or reused for someone else's show. Band name, venue, and show date are locked on that page, pulled straight from what we actually booked, so nothing they do there can drift from the calendar. Everything else is theirs: stage plot (upload it, or just describe or link it), monitor count, in-ears, split snake, hospitality, merch, parking, load-in acknowledgment. If they've played any of our venues in the last six months, their last answers come back pre-filled and they're only updating what changed instead of starting from a blank form.

Tracking where everything stands

Every show carries a status — queued, awaiting, ready to send, follow-up due, follow-up drafted, responded — visible as a colored row in the master spreadsheet, and in a gated internal search page where anyone on the team can pull up a band's full history with us: every venue they've played, every form they've filled out, their stage plots on file. Nobody has to dig through old email threads to answer "have we worked with this band before."

Where this stands today

Live and running the full Fountain Square booking load right now. Still manual: the actual Gmail send — a one-click send through Outlook is the next piece we're building — and the outreach email's specific wording, which is only written for Fountain Square so far. Every other venue already gets the same booking, tracking, and paperwork treatment; they just get generic copy until we write theirs.